

Module 13 - Completing a successful audit

Audit findings:

1. Objective Assessment: As a lead auditor, focus on providing an honest and thorough assessment, not on the number of non-conformities found.
2. Major vs. Minor Non-Conformities:
 - a. Major Non-Conformity: Occurs when a process fails to achieve its intended outcomes. Example: An organization has a procedure but does not conduct management reviews (ISO 9001 clause 9.3).
 - b. Minor Non-Conformity: Occurs when a requirement is not met, but the intended outcomes are still achievable. Example: Some employees haven't completed mandatory training but are still competent (ISO 9001 clause 7.2).
3. Multiple Minor Non-Conformities: If multiple minor non-conformities are related to the same requirement (e.g., training issues), they may be considered as one major non-conformity.

How to reach Audit conclusions?

1. Audit Conclusions vs. Audit Results: Audit results list non-conformities, but audit conclusions assess how well the management system meets the standard's requirements. These conclusions focus on long-term systemic improvements.
2. Key Elements of Audit Conclusion:
 - c. Whether the management system is effective, maintained, and improving.
 - d. The level of conformance with audit criteria.
 - e. How well the system achieves its stated objectives.
3. Major Non-Conformities: If a major non-conformity is found, certification cannot be granted until corrections and corrective actions are reviewed, accepted, and verified by the certification body. A special audit may be required to verify these actions.
4. Minor Non-Conformities: Certification can be granted as long as the certification body accepts the audit client's plans for correction and corrective actions.

The audit conclusion should reflect the effectiveness of the management system and address both immediate fixes and long-term improvements.

Planning the closing meeting:

1. Mandatory Requirement: The closing meeting is required for every certification audit, regardless of the audit type or your experience level.
2. Invitees: Ensure that the management of the audited areas attends. Don't hesitate to ask them to join, as the meeting provides useful information and addresses issues that need attention.
3. Plan in Advance: Schedule the closing meeting early and confirm the time and invitees with the audit client during initial contact. Repeat the details during the opening meeting to ensure everyone is clear.

4. Timing: The closing meeting should be the final part of the audit, held on the last day, and last around 30-60 minutes, depending on the audit findings.

5. Preparation: Complete all audit activities, draw conclusions, and prepare the presentation in advance to ensure the meeting runs on time. Adequate preparation is essential for an impactful presentation.

Good planning and preparation are crucial to delivering an effective closing meeting.

Holding an effective closing meeting:

1. Presentation Tools: Use PowerPoint or similar software, incorporating photographs to illustrate audit findings.

2. Structure of the Presentation:

- a. Introduction: Introduce the audit team and explain the audit objectives, scope, and criteria (mandatory).
- b. Audit Evidence: Inform the client that audit evidence is based on sampling, so there's some uncertainty in the results.
- c. Positives: Highlight what is effective in the management system to build trust.
- d. Opportunities for Improvement: Discuss potential improvements that could benefit the organization.
- e. Non-Conformities: Present evidence for non-conformities factually and objectively, using simple language and visuals.
- f. Audit Conclusions: Explain how conclusions were drawn based on evidence and the significance of non-conformities (major or minor).

3. Next Steps:

- g. Certification body's process and timescale for the audit report.
- h. Steps for addressing non-conformities (corrections and corrective actions).
- i. Certification body's post-audit processes (e.g., certification review).
- j. Appeal or complaint process for the audit client.
- k. Confidentiality reminder.

The goal is to present clear, structured, and factual information to guide the client through the audit results and next steps.

Dealing with feedback at closing meetings:

1. Stay Calm and Focused: If there is disagreement or argument, remain calm and focus on factual points that cannot be disputed. Avoid engaging in arguments.

2. Address New Information: If new information arises at the meeting, explain that it was not available during the audit but can be considered when the client develops corrective action plans.

3. Document Disagreements: Inform the client that any concerns or disagreements will be documented and included in the audit report. Explain the certification body's appeal or dispute process.

4. Tone and Approach: Keep a factual, polite tone, but avoid being apologetic. If poor management practices or leadership issues are found, address them with clear examples. In most cases, it's better to emphasize both positives and areas for improvement.

5. No Non-Conformities? Praise the Organization: If the audit finds no non-conformities or areas for improvement, don't feel uncomfortable—present this finding honestly and praise the organization for their achievements.

The goal is to present the facts clearly and honestly, maintaining professionalism and integrity throughout.

Effective audit report writing

1. Basic Information:
 - a. Certification body and accreditation number.
 - b. Audit client's name and address.
 - c. Type of audit (e.g., initial, stage 1, stage 2, surveillance, recertification).
 - d. Audit objectives, scope, and criteria.
 - e. Dates, locations, and departments audited.
 - f. Details of the lead auditor, audit team, and any technical specialists.
2. Audit Findings:
 - g. All non-conformities, opportunities for improvement, and supporting evidence.
 - h. Audit conclusions, including the degree to which audit criteria were met.
3. Audit Methodology:
 - i. Indicate if remote auditing techniques were used.
 - j. Note any disagreements with audit findings or conclusions.
4. Report Writing Guidelines:
 - k. Present findings clearly, factually, and objectively, avoiding opinions or instructions.
 - l. Avoid terms like "should" or "must" to keep the report neutral.
 - m. Do not include recommendations; only point out opportunities for improvement without offering solutions.
5. Client Responsibility:
 - n. The audit client must analyze audit results, identify root causes for non-conformities, and develop corrective actions.

This approach ensures that the report is accurate, neutral, and aligned with audit principles.

Post-audit activities, corrections, and corrective actions:

1. Audit Report:
 - o. The audit report is written and issued, often during or shortly after the audit, depending on the certification body.
2. Root Cause Analysis:

- p. The audit client must identify root causes for any non-conformities and develop appropriate corrections and corrective actions.
- 3. Review by Lead Auditor:
 - q. The lead auditor reviews the proposed actions to ensure they are suitable for addressing the non-conformity, with clear actions, responsibilities, and timescales.
- 4. Handling Minor Non-Conformities:
 - r. Minor non-conformities are reviewed during the next audit.
- 5. Handling Major Non-Conformities:
 - s. For major non-conformities, the lead auditor must accept and verify the actions, ensuring they are sufficient to resolve the non-conformity.
 - t. This verification can occur during a special audit (either on-site or remote).
- 6. Verification of Corrective Actions:
 - u. It is not enough to just check if actions were completed; the auditor must verify that actions successfully addressed the non-conformity.
 - v. For example, if the action was to create an environmental aspects and impacts register, the auditor checks that it includes all relevant aspects and impacts.
- 7. Special Audit or Next Planned Audit:
 - w. Verification of actions may happen during the next audit or a special follow-up audit, depending on the severity of the non-conformity.

This process ensures that corrective actions are effectively implemented and that non-conformities are addressed properly.

Certification Review Process:

- 1. Audit Report Submission:
 - a. The audit report, along with relevant information about the audit client and evidence of how non-conformities will be addressed, is sent to the certification reviewer.
- 2. Certification Reviewer's Role:
 - b. The certification reviewer evaluates the audit report and supporting documents to determine compliance with the certification body's criteria.
- 3. Review Decision:
 - c. Based on the review, the certification reviewer may:
 - d. Uphold the lead auditor's recommendation.
 - e. Question the recommendation.
 - f. Overturn the recommendation.
- 4. Outcome:

- g. The certification reviewer's decision will dictate whether certification (or recertification) is granted or not, considering the organization's compliance and corrective actions taken.

This process ensures a thorough review before granting or renewing certification.